

Nokia trying to keep afloat

Nokia may slash prices of its smartphones after having lost market share in the European Union

Another Google service bites the dust

Due to slow uptake, Google will stop its health monitoring service Google Health on Jan 1, 2012



The PMP is Dead

Long live the smartphone! No wait...

Long live the tablet!

algorithms and, of course, 'sharing' laid the groundwork for the iPod's entry. With the coming of the iPod, people changed the way they listened to music. You no longer had to shortlist music for the day. The first iPod could store a thousand songs in your pocket! That was more than what most people owned back then, or more aptly - more than what they'd managed to accumulate over P2P networks.

Meanwhile the lesser known Cowons, iRivers and Creatives of the world launched competing products of their own. Soon the MP3 player underwent a mini transition. It became a portable media player. People wanted to watch video on the go and why not? The players had colour screens even before the arrival of the iPod. But most of them were clunky in comparison in terms of user experience. Apple pulled another rabbit out of its hat by revamping the user interface of its sixth-generation iPod Classic and third-generation iPod Nano, even adding video.

Birth of the converged device

About this time, phones were truly transforming into what we're familiar with these days - the ubiquitous smartphone. These devices had started incorporating larger screens, more memory (at least

via expansion cards), codec support and decent battery life. They were slowly but surely inching their way closer to being truly converged devices. If it has everything that you want from a portable media player, why wouldn't you want a single device? One device to rule them all. Well sort of. Phones still had a long way to go.

The true cannibals arrive

By mid 2007, the world witnessed another revolution of sorts in consumer technology. The iPhone was unveiled. The device and certainly its later generations could do much of what Apple's own iPod could and then some more. On a single device, you could now store tons of media, connect wirelessly and even purchase music over the air. No more syncing hassles, at least in theory.

Besides the convenience of carrying a single device, the cost benefits can't be ignored. Spend once and cover all bases, seems to be its mantra. There are very few people remaining who would want to carry around a high-end PMP such as an iPod Touch or Cowon coupled with a very basic phone. It's just not cool.

Now, we also have newer operating systems such as Google's Android OS. Just like the iOS on the iPhone, Android too

has become a 'platform' that can greatly enhance the underlying smartphone's functionality by way of apps. Plus, phones of today have hardware specs that can rival full-fledged computers of just a few years ago. They enjoy better battery life, data connectivity infrastructure, storage and multi-tasking than the first lot of smartphones that now seem like proof-of-concept devices. Over the past year or so, we've also seen a new creature take centre stage. Yes, we're talking about the tablet. What better way to stream video content than on a plus 7-inch screen, right? Each stage of evolution seriously threatens

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Ever so often you come across a "something is dead" headline, right? Late last year, Wired tried to shock you by proclaiming "The web is dead". In the aftermath, the tech intelligentsia pretty much scoffed at the sensationalism at work. Now, here we are with another one of those headlines. Could there be some truth to it? Let's find out...

Times, they are a-changing

The portable media player (PMP) as it was first experienced by the world in the form of the good old Sony Walkman has come a long way. Since that time in the early 80s right until that fateful November of 2001 when the iPod exploded on to the scene, the landscape pretty much remained the same. Sure you had the Discman and the odd idiot walking around with a Boombox, but the concept essentially remained the same - you chose the amount of media you wanted to carry (only music then, in the form of cassettes and later compact discs) and limited yourself to your selection for the day. Digitisation, compression

